

Invasion of Sicily
US paratroopers prepare to bail out over Sicily on 23 July, 1943 *(above)*. In 1942, the M1 carbine *(right)* was given a folding butt stock specially for paratroop use.



M1 CARBINE WITH FOLDING BUTT STOCK

DURING WORLD WAR II the US created five airborne infantry divisions that were elite formations of outstanding fighting effectiveness. They were men not ultimately defined by use of a parachute or landing in a glider, but by their exceptionally high standard of fitness, training, initiative, fighting skills, and aggression. The 82nd Airborne "All American" Division and the 101st Airborne "Screaming Eagles" played a prominent part in some of the toughest fighting in Europe, including the D-Day landings in Normandy.

The US was comparatively slow to develop airborne infantry – the Soviet Union, Japan, Italy, Germany, and Britain all had trained paratroops before the Americans entered the field. It was in August 1942 that 82nd Infantry became the first US division with the Airborne designation. The 101st Airborne was next in seniority, with the 11th, 13th, and 17th Airborne following on in the course of 1943.



Airborne infantry insignia
This silver badge bearing the paratrooper's wings and parachute insignia was worn on the jacket pocket.

The vast majority of US soldiers who fought in World War II were conscript citizen-soldiers, not full-time, professional "lifers". But you could not be drafted into a parachute regiment; conscripts were invited to volunteer to become paratroopers. It was an option that attracted the most ambitious and competitive draftees: men who wanted to make something positive of their time in the army and welcomed a chance to prove themselves. They were offered the lure of extra pay, but although welcome, this was a weak motivation compared with the attraction of joining an elite with its special standards and proudly-worn insignia. For this reason, the number of volunteers for paratroop service always exceeded the places available. Those who got through initial selection and the subsequent hard months of training had to be outstandingly healthy and determined. In the segregated US army all the volunteers were of necessity white, but otherwise they could reasonably be said to come from every part of the US and every area of society. The majority had lived hard lives growing up in the Depression era. The tough conditions they had to endure in training were less of a shock to them than they might have been to recruits from a more pampered generation. It has been said that these were men prepared to risk death for the right to wear silver wings on their pockets and to tuck their trousers into the top of their boots. Strangely, the soldiers of the glider regiments that formed an essential part of airborne divisions were not volunteers and did not receive extra pay, even though landing in gliders was much more dangerous than parachuting.

GOING AIRBORNE

From the start, the airborne divisions pushed physical training to record-breaking levels. A spirit of competition was encouraged between men and units on an extreme programme of forced marches by day and night. Pushed to the limit of endurance, no volunteer ever wanted to surrender to exhaustion or fear – no one wanted to "wash out". The first airborne jump was always a crucial challenge in which the nerve of a fair number of soldiers failed.